



FULL-BLEED HERO PHOTOGRAPH
RECOMMENDED: DUNEDIN RAILWAY STATION / OTAGO PENINSULA

— YOUR JOURNEY BEGINS HERE

Dunedin Relocation Guide

WRITTEN BY ETHICARE RESOURCING · ŌTEPOTI



Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Aotearoa.

Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Dunedin — Ōtepoti, the characterful heritage city of the south.

Built on Scottish foundations and home to New Zealand's oldest university, Dunedin is a compact, affordable city with grand Victorian architecture, a lively student culture, and rare wildlife on the Otago Peninsula. It is the base hospital for the lower South Island.

This guide covers housing, transport, healthcare, finances and where to explore on your days off.



Lifestyle / welcome photograph

RECOMMENDED: DUNEDIN WATERFRONT OR FAMILY

Nau mai, haere mai ki Aotearoa! (Welcome to New Zealand!)

Ngā mihi nui,
The Ethicare Team

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QUICK FACTS

LOCATION

South-east, South Island

CLIMATE

Cool temperate

DRIVE TO QUEENSTOWN

~3.5 hours

MAIN CITY

Dunedin (~135,000)

MAIN HOSPITAL

Dunedin Hospital (tertiary)

NEARBY

Otago Peninsula, Central Otago

The Edinburgh of the south

Dunedin sits at the head of a long harbour on the south-east coast, a city of heritage architecture, students and wildlife. Home to the University of Otago, it has a youthful energy and a strong sense of history.

135K

CITY RESIDENTS

1869

FOUNDED NZ'S FIRST UNIVERSITY –
OTAGO

1

OF THE WORLD'S STEEPEST
STREETS – BALDWIN ST

Why many professionals enjoy Dunedin

- Affordable, characterful heritage living
- A major teaching hospital and the country's oldest university
- Rare wildlife on the Otago Peninsula
- A vibrant, youthful student culture

Heritage, scholars and wildlife

Dunedin's Scottish heritage shows in its architecture, street names and festivals, while the University of Otago gives the city a young, creative and intellectual energy.

The Dunedin Railway Station, the Octagon and the city's Victorian and Edwardian buildings are among the finest in the country.

Kāi Tahu are the tangata whenua of the south, and the Otago Peninsula is a globally important home for albatross, penguins and sea lions.



Cultural moment

RECOMMENDED: DUNEDIN LANDMARK

“

Grand old architecture, a famous university and albatross on the headland – Dunedin is unlike anywhere else in New Zealand.

ON LIFE IN DUNEDIN

Getting around

Here is how people get around Dunedin day to day – and what to know about driving in New Zealand.

DRIVING

A car suits the hilly city and wider Otago; State Highway 1 runs north and south.

BUSES

The Orbus network serves the city and suburbs.

AIR

Dunedin Airport offers domestic flights and some trans-Tasman services.

WALKING

The compact central Octagon and campus area are walkable and lively.

On the road

- New Zealanders drive on the left
- You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for up to 12 months before converting to a NZ one
- A local transport card makes buses and trains easy
- Keep your overseas licence and any translation handy when you first arrive

A year in the local climate

Dunedin has a cool temperate climate — mild summers and cool winters, with changeable coastal weather. It is greener and cooler than much of the country.

Summer

DEC – FEB

18–22°

AVG DAYTIME

Autumn

MAR – MAY

13–18°

AVG DAYTIME

Winter

JUN – AUG

7–11°

AVG DAYTIME

Spring

SEP – NOV

12–16°

AVG DAYTIME



Seasonal / scenic photograph

RECOMMENDED: OTAGO PENINSULA / TUNNEL BEACH

Coastal and changeable, with cool crisp winters and mild summers. Layers and a warm waterproof jacket are essential year-round.

Healthcare in Dunedin

Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora delivers care across Otago from Dunedin Hospital – the largest hospital south of Christchurch and the base for the lower South Island.

Dunedin Hospital

The major tertiary base hospital for Otago and Southland – full specialist, surgical and emergency services, with a new hospital under construction.

Southland Hospital (Invercargill)

Serves the far south with acute and medical care, referring complex cases to Dunedin.

Teaching & research

Home to the University of Otago medical school – a leading centre for clinical training and research.

Private & ACC

Mercy Hospital in Dunedin offers private surgical care; ACC covers accidents for everyone.

Public & private

- Public healthcare is funded through general taxation
- ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone
- Private hospitals offer elective procedures and shorter waits
- Many residents hold private health insurance alongside the public system

GPs, pharmacies & urgent care

Registering with a GP and dentist

After you settle in, enrol with a local GP (General Practitioner). Enrolment means subsidised visits — typically around NZ\$50–\$70 when enrolled, more if you are a casual patient. Many practices allow online enrolment once you have an address. Dental care is private; expect roughly NZ\$90–\$150 for a check-up.

Pharmacies

Pharmacies are found throughout the region. Prescriptions are partly subsidised once you are enrolled with a GP — commonly a small standard charge per item.

Emergency & after-hours

- **Emergency Departments** — for urgent or critical care; in an emergency, dial 111
- **Urgent care clinics** — accident & medical clinics offer extended-hours care
- **Healthline 0800 611 116** — free 24/7 advice from registered nurses

Setting up your finances

Getting your finances in order early makes day-to-day life much easier. Most of this can be started before you arrive.

Opening a bank account

The major banks are ANZ, ASB, BNZ, Kiwibank and Westpac. You will usually need your passport, work or resident visa, and proof of a NZ address. Many banks let you start online before arrival, then activate in person. Ask for online banking and a debit card at the same time.

Tax (IRD number)

Every worker needs an IRD number from Inland Revenue. Apply online once you have a NZ address and bank account; processing usually takes around 7–10 working days. Give the number to your payroll team as soon as it arrives so the correct tax is applied. Wages are commonly paid fortnightly.

● Tip

Start your bank account application before you fly — having an account number ready makes your IRD application and payroll setup much smoother.

KiwiSaver & sending money home

KiwiSaver is a government-supported retirement savings scheme. On a work visa you can usually opt in or out. Contributions are a percentage of your pay (commonly 3%, 4%, 6%, 8% or 10%), with employers contributing at least 3%. You can withdraw your funds if you permanently leave New Zealand.

Sending money overseas: banks can transfer internationally, but specialist services such as Wise or OFX are often cheaper and faster. Always compare the exchange rate and the fees before moving larger amounts.

SET UP	WHY IT MATTERS	WHEN
Bank account	Receive salary, pay bills locally	Before / on arrival
IRD number	Be taxed correctly	First weeks
KiwiSaver	Retirement savings + employer top-up	When you start work
ACC	No-fault accident cover	Automatic

What life costs in Dunedin

Dunedin is among the more affordable cities in New Zealand, with heritage homes and student-influenced rents keeping costs below the big centres.

\$500/wk

3-BED HOUSE (APPROX. MEDIAN)

\$2.85/L

APPROX. PETROL PRICE

Left

SIDE OF THE ROAD

EVERYDAY ITEM	APPROX. PRICE (NZ\$)
1 litre of milk	\$2.50 – \$3.50
Loaf of bread	\$2.50 – \$4.00
Dozen eggs	\$7 – \$10
Flat white coffee	\$5.50 – \$6.50
Mid-range meal for one	\$25 – \$40
Monthly gym membership	\$60 – \$100
Home broadband	\$75 – \$100 / month

Prices are indicative and change over time – use the calculators at the back of this guide for a personalised estimate.

An example monthly budget

A rough single-person monthly budget for a Dunedin renter. Yours will vary with lifestyle, household size and suburb.

CATEGORY	APPROX. MONTHLY (NZ\$)
Rent (room / small 1-bed)	\$1,100 – \$1,800
Power & water	\$170 – \$260
Internet	\$75 – \$100
Public transport / fuel	\$150 – \$260
Groceries	\$450 – \$650
Mobile phone	\$30 – \$50
Entertainment	\$150 – \$310
Estimated total	\$2,200 – \$3,400

Make it personal

- Use Numbeo to compare Dunedin with your current city
- Map your own incomings and outgoings with the Sorted budget planner (sorted.org.nz)

A note from Sophie

A personal word from our Founder on what makes Dunedin special — and who it tends to suit.



● SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

Dunedin has a character all of its own — heritage streets, a famous university and wildlife you won't see anywhere else in the country. It's affordable, walkable and full of personality.

The winters are cooler, so pack accordingly, but the medical school and the base hospital make it a genuinely rewarding place to build a clinical career.

Sophie Careem · Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing

● From the Ethicare team

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with every step of your move to Dunedin — from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Finding a place to live

Dunedin offers characterful heritage homes and hillside villas at affordable prices, with harbourside and coastal options across the city.



Housing / suburb photograph

RECOMMENDED: SUBURBAN STREET OR APARTMENTS

Useful property websites

- trademe.co.nz/property – NZ's largest rental marketplace
- realestate.co.nz – nationwide rentals and homes for sale

A guide to the areas

An orientation to the main areas of Dunedin — each with its own character, price point and who it tends to suit.

Central & North Dunedin

Near the Octagon and university — lively, walkable and student-influenced.

Roslyn & Maori Hill

Established hillside suburbs with character homes and harbour views.

St Clair & St Kilda

Seaside suburbs by the surf beach, popular with families and professionals.

Mosgiel

A flatter, affordable satellite town on the city's edge, popular with families.

Across the wider region

Central & North Dunedin

Near the Octagon and university — lively and walkable.

Roslyn & Maori Hill

Established hillside suburbs with character and harbour views.

St Clair & St Kilda

Seaside suburbs by the surf beach, popular with families.

Mosgiel

A flatter, affordable satellite town popular with families.

A tip on choosing

- Think about your commute to work and school zones if you have children
- Where you live can decide which state school your children attend — check the zone before you sign
- Many people rent for a few months first to get to know the areas

Utilities, rates & rubbish

POWER & GAS

Choose from providers like Genesis, Mercury, Meridian and Contact. Compare rates on Powerswitch (powerswitch.org.nz).

WATER & RATES

Council rates fund local services; if you rent, rates are usually included in your rent.

RUBBISH & RECYCLING

Kerbside collection is run by the local council, with separate bins for rubbish, recycling and food scraps.

INTERNET

Most homes have fibre broadband; Spark, One NZ and 2degrees are the main providers.

Set-up quick links

Compare power

powerswitch.org.nz

Post & parcels

nzpost.co.nz

Tenancy advice

tenancy.govt.nz

Where to shop

Dunedin offers malls, town centres and weekend markets. A few of the main ones:

George Street (CBD)

The recently rebuilt main shopping street.

The Meridian & Wall Street

Central-city malls in the heart of town.

Octagon & Moray Place

Cafés, galleries and boutiques around the city centre.

Markets

The Otago Farmers' Market at the historic Railway Station every Saturday.

Supermarkets & groceries

New Zealand's supermarkets fall into a few main groups. Knowing the difference helps you balance budget and convenience.

Pak'nSave

The cheapest of the big chains — a no-frills, bulk-buy warehouse format. Best for budget shopping.

Woolworths

Mid-range and widespread, with strong online shopping and delivery (formerly Countdown).

New World

More upmarket, with a wider fresh and specialty range.

Four Square & FreshChoice

Smaller neighbourhood stores for convenience and top-ups.

Dunedin has Pak'nSave, Woolworths and New World across the city; Mosgiel has its own supermarkets. Bring your own bags — single-use plastic bags are banned.

Specialty & international food

One of the joys of settling into Dunedin is finding the flavours of home — or exploring new ones.

Halal & South Asian

Halal and Indian grocers serve the student community; many supermarket lines are halal-certified.

Asian groceries

Asian supermarkets and eateries cluster near the university and central city.

World food

A lively, student-driven food scene with global cuisine around the Octagon.

Smaller independent stores open and close over time — a quick search for "halal butcher near me" or your home cuisine will surface the current options near your suburb.

Places of worship

Dunedin reflects New Zealand's spiritual diversity, with welcoming communities across many faiths.

Dunedin has Christian churches of many denominations (with strong Presbyterian roots), a mosque, and Hindu and Buddhist communities.

Finding your community

- Most faith communities list service times and locations online
- Many warmly welcome newcomers and visitors
- They can be one of the quickest ways to build a support network when you arrive

Wildlife, heritage and the coast

Dunedin rewards the curious – albatross and penguins on the peninsula, heritage architecture in town, and the wild Otago coast on the doorstep.



Recreation hero photograph

RECOMMENDED: OTAGO PENINSULA / TUNNEL BEACH

Don't-miss experiences

- See the albatross colony at Taiaroa Head
- Spot penguins and sea lions on the Otago Peninsula
- Walk to dramatic Tunnel Beach
- Climb the world's steepest street, Baldwin Street

Ten things not to miss

A starter list to get to know Dunedin and the wider region.

- 1 Otago Peninsula wildlife**
Albatross, penguins and sea lions at Taiaroa Head.
- 2 Dunedin Railway Station**
One of NZ's most photographed buildings.
- 3 Baldwin Street**
Climb the world's steepest residential street.
- 4 Tunnel Beach**
A dramatic coastal walk to a hand-carved tunnel.
- 5 Larnach Castle**
NZ's only castle, on the peninsula.
- 6 St Clair Beach**
Surf, the salt-water pool and the Esplanade.
- 7 Otago Museum & Toitū**
The city's excellent museums — free to enter.
- 8 Speight's Brewery**
Tour the historic 'pride of the south'.
- 9 Signal Hill**
A lookout over the city and harbour.
- 10 Sandfly Bay**
A wild beach with sea lions and a steep dune.

Travel from Dunedin

Dunedin is a great base for exploring. Some favourite weekend escapes:

Central Otago (~1.5 hrs)

Wineries, Cromwell and historic gold towns.

Queenstown (~3.5 hrs)

The South Island's adventure capital.

The Catlins (~1.5 hrs)

Waterfalls, forests and a wild coastline.

Oamaru (~1.5 hrs)

Victorian heritage and little blue penguins.

Flying onward

- Domestic flights reach the main centres in around 1–2 hours
- Book early for the best fares on Air New Zealand and Jetstar
- Many regions are also linked by scenic road and rail journeys

Schooling & study

Dunedin offers a full range of early childhood education, schools and tertiary study.

Early Childhood Education (ECE)

Kindergartens, daycare, Montessori, kōhanga reo and home-based care for ages 0–5. Government 20-hours funding applies for ages 3–5.

Primary & intermediate

State, state-integrated and private schools for Years 1–8.

Secondary

Years 9–13, working towards NCEA, the national qualification.

Tertiary

Universities and institutes of technology across the country.

School terms run late January to mid-December, in four terms with two-week breaks in April, July and October.

School zones come first

In New Zealand, where you live usually determines which state school your children can attend. For many families, the school decision leads the choice of where to rent or buy.

In-zone = guaranteed

Children living inside a school's enrolment zone are guaranteed a place at that school.

Out-of-zone = ballot

If you live outside the zone you can still apply, but places aren't guaranteed — popular schools run a ballot for limited spots.

Zones are street-by-street

Boundaries can run down the middle of a street, so check the exact address.

● **The order that works best**

1) Shortlist schools you like → 2) Check each school's zone map → 3) Search for rentals inside that zone → 4) Confirm the address is in-zone before you sign.

Childcare for working families

Early childhood (0–5). Daycare, kindergartens, Montessori and home-based care are widely available. The government's 20 Hours ECE funding subsidises care for ages 3–5 at participating centres.

Before & after school (OSCAR). Many schools and providers run breakfast clubs, after-school care and holiday programmes. Subsidies may be available through Work and Income for eligible families.

TYPE OF CARE	APPROX. COST (NZ\$)
Full-time daycare (under 3)	\$350 – \$450 / week before subsidies
20 Hours ECE (ages 3–5)	Up to 20 hrs/week subsidised; extra hours charged
After-school care (OSCAR)	\$5 – \$15 per afternoon, varies by provider
School holiday programme	\$40 – \$60 per day, activity-based

Costs are indicative and vary by provider and suburb. If you'll work shifts, ask providers about flexible hours.

Dunedin for families

Beyond school and work, Dunedin is an easy, outdoorsy place to raise a family.

FREE & OUTDOORS

Beaches, the Botanic Garden and peninsula wildlife — much of the fun is free.

RAINY-DAY OPTIONS

Otago Museum (with Tropical Forest), Toitū and the Tūhura science centre.

LIBRARIES & PLUNKET

Free libraries run children's programmes; Plunket supports young families.

GETTING AROUND

A compact city, though hilly — the flat areas and beaches suit families.

Settling kids in

- Children often settle fastest through school, sport and weekend activities
- Local clubs — football, netball, rugby, swimming — are inexpensive and welcoming
- They're a great way for the whole family to meet people

Pre-departure checklist

Work through these before you fly. Keep digital and printed copies of everything important.

Documents

- ☐ Passport + valid NZ visa (printed too)
- ☐ Job offer & employment contract
- ☐ Qualifications & certificates
- ☐ References & employment history

Money & travel

- ☐ Apply online for a NZ bank account
- ☐ Documents ready for your IRD number
- ☐ Confirm airline baggage allowance
- ☐ Book temporary accommodation

Your first weeks

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Move into your accommodation | ☐ Open / activate your bank account |
| ☐ Apply for your IRD number | ☐ Get a NZ SIM card |
| ☐ Register with a local GP | ☐ Set up power, water and internet |
| ☐ Learn your transport routes to work | ☐ Save 111 and Healthline in your phone |
| ☐ Find your nearest pharmacy & supermarket | ☐ Explore your local neighbourhood |

● You're not alone

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with any of these steps – from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Key numbers & contacts

In any emergency – police, fire or ambulance – dial **111**.

Emergency & health

Emergency	111
Healthline	0800 611 116
Mental health	Call/text 1737
Police (non-urgent)	105

Everyday services

Tax (IRD)	ird.govt.nz
Immigration	immigration.govt.nz
AA roadside	0800 500 222
Local council	govt.nz/organisations

Banks

ANZ	anz.co.nz
ASB	asb.co.nz
BNZ	bnz.co.nz
Kiwibank	kiwibank.co.nz
Westpac	westpac.co.nz

Community & expat groups

One of the quickest ways to settle in is to find your people. Dunedin has active communities for almost every interest and background.

Facebook groups

Search for groups like "Expats in Dunedin", your home-country community, and local suburb buy/sell and parents' groups.

Meetup & interest groups

Meetup.com lists hiking, sport, hobby and newcomer groups — a relaxed way to meet people.

Sports & cultural clubs

Local football, netball, rugby and cricket clubs, plus cultural and faith communities, all welcome newcomers.

Workplace networks

Many hospitals and employers have social clubs and buddy systems for new and international staff.

Rainbow / LGBTQ+ community

- New Zealand is welcoming and progressive — marriage equality has been law since 2013
- There are strong legal protections against discrimination
- OutLine Aotearoa offers rainbow mental-health support (0800 688 5463)

Everyday Māori & Kiwi phrases

Te reo Māori is part of everyday life, and Kiwis have their own slang too.

Te reo Māori

Kia ora Hello / thanks

Nau mai, haere mai Welcome

Whānau Family

Hauora Health & wellbeing

Manaakitanga Hospitality, kindness

Mōrena Good morning

Ka kite anō See you later

Tamariki Children

Ngā mihi nui Many thanks

Aotearoa New Zealand

Kiwi slang

Sweet as Great / no worries

Keen Up for it

Dairy Corner shop

Jandals Flip-flops

Flatting Shared renting

Chur Cheers / thanks

Heaps Lots

Togs Swimwear

Shout Your turn to pay

Knackered Tired

Work out your cost of living.

Use these tools to estimate what life in Dunedin would really cost for you and your family.

Cost-of-living calculators

Compare cities (Numbeo)	numbeo.com/cost-of-living
Budget planner (Sorted)	sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner
Living-costs data (Stats NZ)	stats.govt.nz
Take-home pay (IRD)	ird.govt.nz

We hope you've found this guide useful. Moving to the other side of the world is a big step, and there's a lot to take in – so please don't feel you have to have it all figured out at once.

Whatever stage you're at, we're always happy to talk anything through – the big decisions or the small worries. Just reach out to your Ethicare contact whenever you need us.

Ngā mihi nui

The Ethicare team



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